From a provider's data to a slot: the template, step by step

Status: prototype. Everything in this guide is built and tested on the prototype core, using a real home's data (a UK home with a Sunsynk inverter and an Octopus smart meter). Where something is not built yet, it says so in section 9.

This guide explains two things:

1. **The journey.** How a number that a provider sends (an inverter, a smart meter, a weather service) becomes one slot in the home's timeline.
2. **Why it is provider-agnostic.** Why adding, replacing or removing a provider does not mean changing the core.

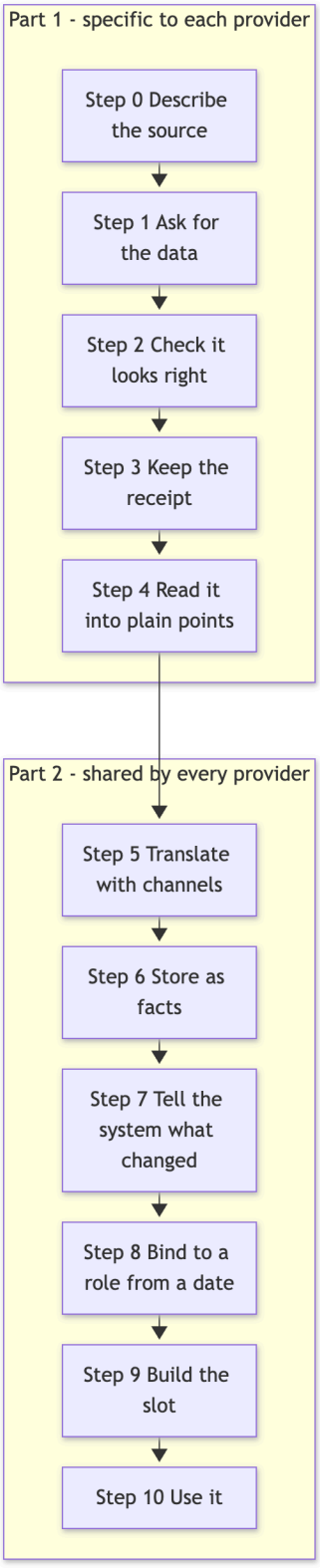
It is organised around the **processor template**, the standard shape every provider follows. If you understand the template, you understand how any provider is added.

---

1. The idea in one picture

A slot is a short, fixed period of a home's day (15, 30 or 60 minutes, chosen per home) with one row of numbers: how much solar, how much the home used, what came from the grid, what it cost, and where each figure came from.

Every provider takes the same road to get there. Only the first part of the road is specific to the provider. The rest is shared.



Part 1 is written once per provider. Part 2 is the core and is never edited for a new provider. Step 5 translates units, signs and limits. Step 10 is dashboards, the planner, group views and device control.

---

2. The template, step by step

For each step: **what happens**, **what the provider side supplies**, and **what the core does**.

Step 0. Describe the source

What happens. Before any data moves, the provider is described in plain terms, once. This is a short record, not code.

The provider side supplies:

Question	Example answer (an inverter cloud)
How does it state time?	Hours and minutes on the plant's local clock, date from the request
What does a sign mean?	Grid positive means importing; battery positive means discharging
What are the units?	Watts for power, percent for battery charge
How does it say "no data"?	An empty list, or an error code
Does it correct old values later?	No
How far back can we ask?	90 days
How long does a reading hold?	5 minutes (used when filling the time between readings)

The core does. Keeps this description with the source, so anyone can see what the data means. The "how long a reading holds" answer is read by the slot builder, so it needs no provider-specific rule.

Step 1. Ask for the data

What happens. The processor requests the window of data it needs, using the home's credentials.

The provider side supplies: the address to call, how to sign in, and which period to ask for.

The core does. Provides safe fetching (timeouts, retries, never logging secrets).

Step 2. Check it looks right

What happens. The reply is checked against the shape the provider documents. If it is not that shape (an outage page, a changed format), it is **quarantined**: kept for inspection, but it produces no data.

Why it matters. A reply of the wrong shape must never turn into zeros in someone's energy figures. The slot then shows the data as missing, honestly.

Step 3. Keep the receipt

What happens. The exact reply is saved, with a fingerprint and the time it arrived.

Why it matters. Every figure can be traced back to the exact reply it came from, and the reply can be read again later if the reading rules improve.

Step 4. Read it into the provider's own points

What happens. A pure reading step turns the reply into a plain list: **point name, time, number**. Nothing else. It keeps the provider's own names (for example `PV`, `Grid`, `Battery`, `pv_kw`) and the provider's own numbers, including signs. It converts nothing and decides nothing.

The provider side supplies: this one reading step. It is the main piece of provider-specific work, and it has no side effects, so it can be tested with a saved real reply.

The core does. Nothing yet. This is the hand-over point.

Step 5. Translate with channels

What happens. This is where provider-agnosticism lives. A **channel** is one row of data that says: "*this point of this provider becomes this standard measurement.*" A channel carries:

Part	What it does	Example
Point	The provider's own name	`grid_kw`
Measurement	The standard one it becomes	`grid_import_w`
Scale and shift	Converts units	kW to W: multiply by 1000
Part	Which part of a signed number	`positive` for import, `negative` for export, `abs` for the size of either sign
Limits	The range a believable value stays within	solar between 0 and 60,000 W

One signed point can feed two standard measurements. The same grid figure becomes *import* when positive and *export* when negative.

Beyond instant readings, the same translation handles three more shapes: a **period** (an amount over a time span), a **counter** (a running total such as a smart plug's energy meter, where the core works out the energy for each period and copes with the counter resetting, wrapping or restarting) and an **event** (something that happened, such as a charger being plugged in). Devices that are not inverters or meters, such as heat pumps, EV chargers and plugs, have roles of their own.

What the core does with each value:

Situation	What happens
Value is inside its limits	Converted and passed on
Value is outside its limits (say 500,000 kW of solar)	Refused, and the refusal is recorded. It is never stored as a fact
Value is not a number	Refused and recorded
The provider sends a point nobody mapped	Reported as "unmapped", never dropped silently
An empty reply where data was required	An error that shows in the sync log, not a quiet success

The standard measurements are the same for every provider. That is why the slot builder, further down, never needs to know which provider it is.

Step 6. Store as facts

What happens. The translated numbers are stored as **facts**. Facts are never overwritten: if a provider later corrects a value, the new value is added as a newer version and the old one is kept. This is what lets the system show what was known at any past moment.

Protections built in:

- A provider can only write into its **own** series. A new provider cannot overwrite another provider's readings by accident or by mislabelling.
- The same period sent twice in one batch keeps the last value, instead of failing the whole batch.
- Sending identical data again stores nothing new.

Step 7. Tell the system what changed

What happens. The processor tells the core which stretch of time changed, so the affected slots are rebuilt.

Safety. If a sync stops half-way, the next one still finds the facts the first one wrote and rebuilds from there. Before this was fixed, a corrected day could stay wrong for ever.

Step 8. Bind to a role, from a date

What happens. The slot builder does not ask for "the Sunsynk". It asks for a **role**, such as "the inverter's 5-minute readings". A **binding** says which provider fills that role for this home, and from when.

The roles today:

Role	What the builder uses it for
Inverter, 5-minute	Solar, house use, grid and battery power, charge level
Inverter, daily totals	The inverter's own daily counters, used to correct the slot figures
Meter energy	The supplier's official import, export and gas figures
Gas calorific value	Converting gas volume to energy
Carbon intensity	Grid carbon per period
Weather temperature	Outdoor temperature
EV charge dispatch	Smart-charge periods
Solar forecast	The forecast of record, with priorities between forecast sources

A binding is just a row: *role, provider, valid from, valid to*. Changing it is a data change, not a code change (and it can be done on the **Providers** screen, which shows what would change before anything is kept), and it takes effect **from a chosen date**. Slots before that date never change.

Two or more devices of one kind (two inverters, two batteries) are two bindings at the same time, and their figures are added.

Step 9. Build the slot

What happens. The builder reads the facts of whichever providers are bound, and builds each slot:

1. Takes the 5-minute readings and works out the energy in each slot, holding each reading for as long as its provider says it holds.
2. Corrects the slot figures to match the inverter's own daily totals, when they agree closely enough.
3. Prefers the official meter figure over the inverter's clamp figure when the meter has it.
4. Prices the energy using the home's tariff, in the home's currency.
5. Records the slot's **lineage**: which provider each figure came from, and whether it is final, still provisional, or missing.

Slot length. Everything above works at 15, 30 or 60 minutes. The slot length is set per home and the same steps apply.

Missing data. If a figure is not there, the slot says so. It is never filled with zero or a guess.

Step 10. Use the result

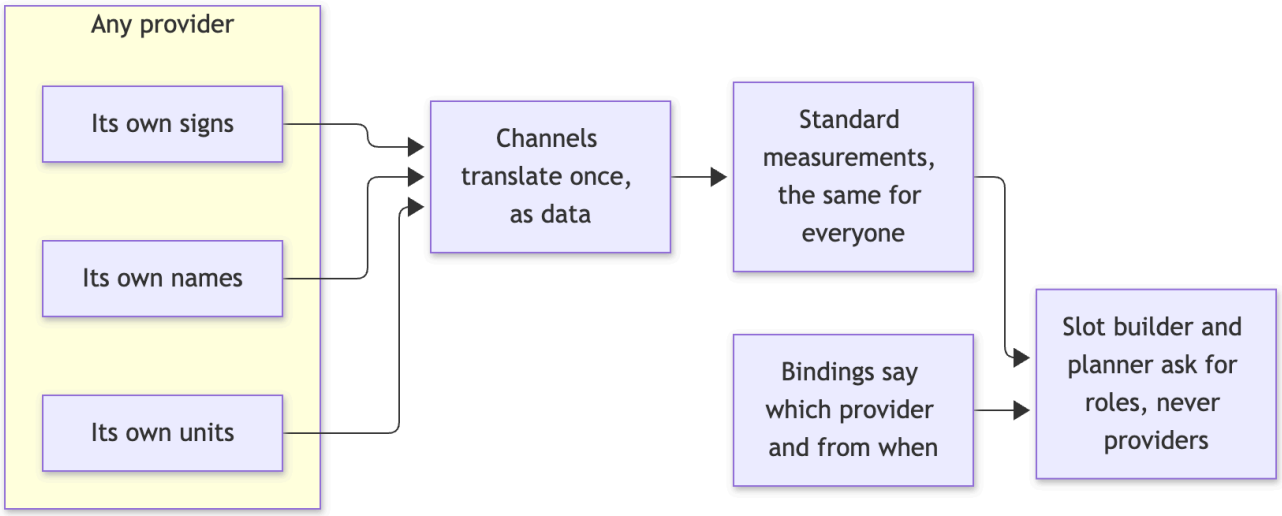
The same slots feed everything downstream, and they read the same bindings, so they cannot disagree about which provider a figure came from:

- the dashboards and the explanation of any single slot, step by step;
- the planner's input arrays for Predbat and PredHeat style planning;
- group views across several homes (money is added only within one currency);
- device control, where a command counts as done only when the **device itself** reports the new state.

---

3. Why this is provider-agnostic

Three rules do the work.



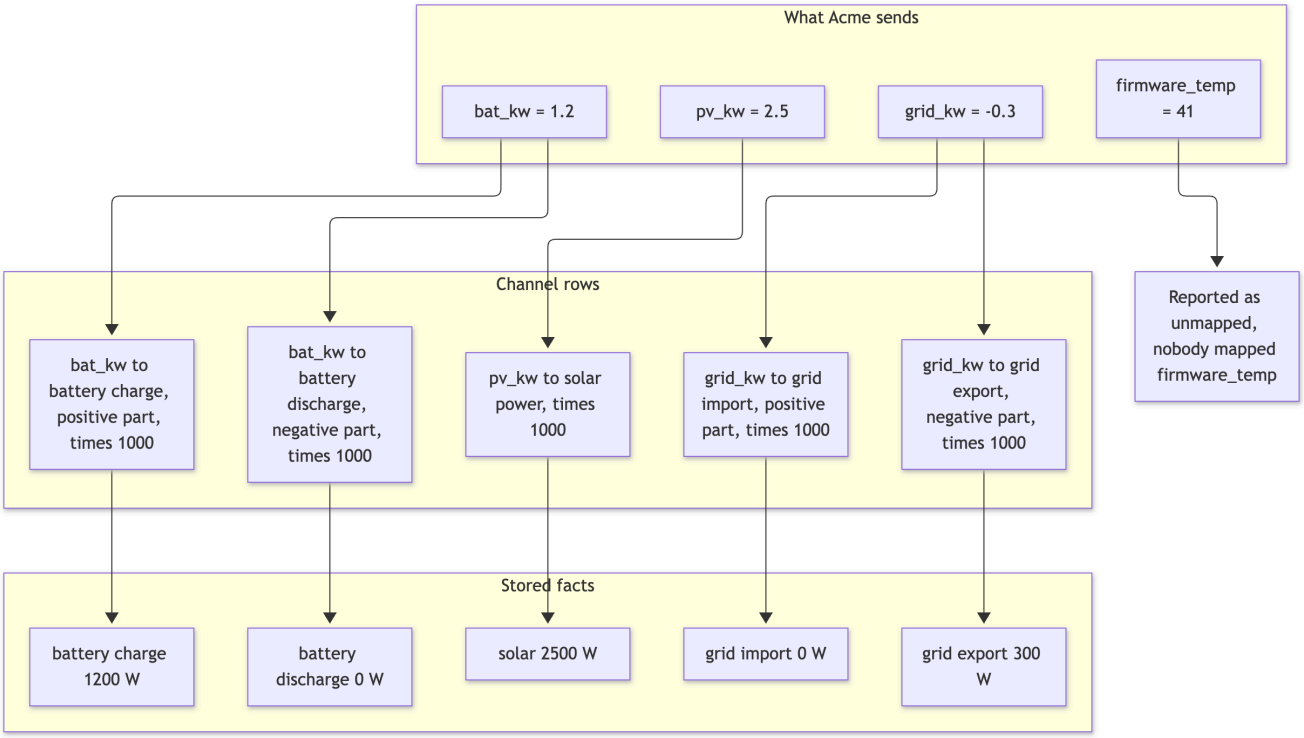
1. **Translate at the door.** Every provider's data is converted to the same standard measurements the moment it arrives, by channel rows. Past that door, nothing is provider-specific.
2. **Ask for roles.** The engine asks for what it needs ("the inverter's 5-minute readings"), never for a named provider.
3. **Decide by date, in data.** Which provider fills a role is a dated row. Switching, adding and removing are row changes that leave the past untouched.

The result for a client: **a new provider is a small reading step, some channel rows and a binding. The slot builder, the planner and the group views are not edited.**

---

4. A worked example: a provider that reports in kW

To show it works, a second inverter vendor, called "Acme" here, was set up as pure data. It reports power in **kilowatts**, with **one signed grid figure** and **one signed battery figure**, which is deliberately different from the original inverter (watts, with the sign convention described in step 0).



Then Acme was bound to the inverter role **from a chosen date** on a real home.

What was checked. Acme's data was the real inverter's own data, re-expressed in kilowatts and signed figures. From the chosen date, the slots built from Acme matched the slots built from the real inverter to within one part in a million on solar, house use, import, export, battery charge and discharge, and total cost. Slots **before** the date were byte-identical to before. A rebuild "as known before the change" still gave the old result. No line of the slot builder or planner was edited.

The same kind of test was repeated for the meter role, the carbon role, a provider reporting every 15 minutes instead of 5, two inverters at once (a real inverter split 40 and 60 between two devices gave identical slots), and for slot lengths of 15, 30 and 60 minutes.

---

5. Adding, switching and removing a provider

Everything below is done while the system runs, and none of it rewrites history.

What you want	What is done	What happens to the past
Add a provider	Describe it, add channel rows, bind it from a date	Unchanged
Switch to another provider	Bind the new one from the switch date; the old one ends there	Slots before the date are identical to before
Add a second device of one kind	Bind it beside the first	Unchanged; figures are added from the date
Remove a provider	End its binding at a date	Unchanged; the role has no source from then on

What you want	What is done	What happens to the past
A provider goes quiet	Nothing to do. Slots show as waiting or missing with a reason	Nothing is faked
Retire a meter	Mark the device retired	The home keeps its prices; tariff agreements are not touched

Two safeguards sit on every change:

- **Preview first.** Before a change is made, the system can show how many slots would change, in which figures, and by how much, without keeping anything.
- **A reason is required** whenever a change would alter slots that were already built. The reason is kept with the change.

---

6. What you can trust at each point

Question	Answer
Can I see where a figure came from?	Yes. Each slot records the provider of its main figures, and the exact original reply is kept
Can a bad reading corrupt the timeline?	Out-of-range values are refused and recorded; a reply of the wrong shape is quarantined
Can a missing reading look like zero?	No. Missing stays missing
Can I see the timeline as it was known last month?	Yes. Facts and bindings are kept as versions
Can one provider overwrite another's data?	No. A provider can only write into its own series
Does a half-finished sync lose data?	No. The next sync finds and rebuilds what the first one wrote
Do the planner and the dashboard agree?	Yes, within 0.1 percent in the tests, because they read the same bindings

---

7. The checklist for a new provider

#	Piece	Who supplies it	Size
1	The description of the source (step 0)	Provider side	A short record
2	How to ask and how to check the reply (steps 1 to 3)	Provider side	A few lines, using the shared fetching
3	The reading step (step 4)	Provider side	The one real piece of provider-specific work
4	The channel rows (step 5)	Provider side	One row per point

#	Piece	Who supplies it	Size
5	The binding (step 8)	Operator	One row, with a date
6	Preview, then confirm	Operator	A review of the impact

Everything else in the journey is shared and already built.

---

8. Slot lengths

The slot length is a setting of each home: 15, 30 or 60 minutes. A 45-minute slot is not allowed because it does not divide the hour. The journey is identical at all three lengths. The provider-switch, channel, two-device, crash-safety and control tests all pass at 15, 30 and 60 minutes.

Two things to know:

- A 30-minute meter reading inside a 15-minute slot is shared out in proportion to the inverter's 5-minute shape, or evenly if that shape is missing.
- An hourly slot uses a meter figure only when both of its half-hours have one; otherwise it falls back to the inverter figure.

---

9. What is not built yet

Said plainly, so there are no surprises.

Not built	Detail
Push ingest	Everything is pulled today. A device or gateway cannot yet post its readings to the core (for example a smart plug's webhook or MQTT). This is the real entry door for IoT devices
Real IoT device processors	Counters, events and the heating roles are built and tested on synthetic data. A **Devices page with a labelled synthetic IoT home** (a smart plug, heat pump, EV charger, battery and sensor) shows them working end to end, including a simulated period and a test command. No real plug, heat pump or EV charger has been connected
A real vendor control driver	The control path (command, device read-back, effect check, late acknowledgement) works against a simulated device. A real driver needs a chosen vendor, its API and a test device
Tariff catalogues as providers	Tariff and price feeds fill the tariff store the builder prices from. They are not part of this journey
Rules as data	Rules such as "the official meter beats the clamp" are still in the builder. They stay there until a provider needs a different rule

Not built	Detail
Sign-in and row-level security	Out of scope for the prototype. The check "may this person control this home" exists and is enforced when a person acts
A real second inverter vendor	The design is proven with a vendor built as test data on real figures. A true second vendor's live feed is the next real test

10. Where to look

Topic	Document
The architecture in diagrams	`docs/slot-engine-architecture.md`
The reasoning and the plan	`docs/slot-engine-solution.md`
Control with device read-back	`docs/control-readback.md`
Groups and access	`docs/groups-and-access.md`
The processor template itself	`src/adapters/_template.js`